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Prof. Stavroula Kousta
Chief Editor, *Nature Human Behaviour*

Dear Prof. Kousta and editorial team,

We are pleased to submit our manuscript, “*German parties shifted towards intuition-based rhetoric after the far right's parliamentary breakthrough*”, for consideration as an Article in *Nature Human Behaviour*. Analysing 4.5 million tweets from over 2,000 German politicians and 59,170 Bundestag speeches (2015–2025), we show that the rhetoric of German political elites has shifted measurably from evidence-based towards intuition-based approaches to truth. Right-leaning actors, above all the Alternative für Deutschland (AfD), consistently anchor the intuition end of this distribution, and the AfD’s 2017 entry into the Bundestag coincides with a discrete, chamber-wide decline in evidence-based rhetoric ($\beta = -0.421$, $P < 0.001$) that is robust to topic-mix controls.

How political elites ground their claims to truth is central to democratic deliberation, yet the evidence on epistemic drift in elite discourse comes almost entirely from the United States. Building on Lasser et al. (*Nature Human Behaviour*, 2023) and Aroyehun et al. (*Nature Human Behaviour*, 2025), we provide the first cross-platform, multiparty European evidence on this dynamic, replicated in two arenas with opposite failure modes (an open, algorithmically curated platform and a procedurally rigid parliament), so that a shift visible in both is unlikely to be a platform artefact. The AfD’s well-dated 2017 entry into a chamber that had excluded the extreme right for the entire post-war period offers one of the cleanest temporal anchors available in any contemporary democracy, and our finding that far-right “contagion” extends beyond policy positions and issue salience to epistemic style speaks to readers across political science, social psychology, communication research and computational social science.

Our measure, a distributed dictionary representation of evidence- and intuition-based language, is supported by two pre-registered human validation surveys ($N = 47$ for the German dictionaries; $N = 284$ at the document level, AUC = 0.72), alternative-embedding and bootstrap checks, and mixed-effects breakpoint models. We also wish to flag that this is, to our knowledge, among the first studies to use Twitter/X data obtained under the EU Digital Services Act Article 40 — a demonstration of the new access regime for platform-scale research that should be of independent interest.

Declarations. This manuscript is not under consideration elsewhere, no related manuscripts by the authors are under consideration or in press, and we have had no prior discussions with a *Nature Human Behaviour* editor about this work. We have opted for single-blind peer review.

Suggested reviewers (expertise in computational political communication, populism and text-as-data methods; no conflicts of interest with the authors):

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Thank you for considering this submission.

Sincerely,
Peer Saleth
on behalf of all co-authors: Segun T. Aroyehun, Fabio Carrella, Christoph M. Abels, Stephan Lewandowsky, David Garcia